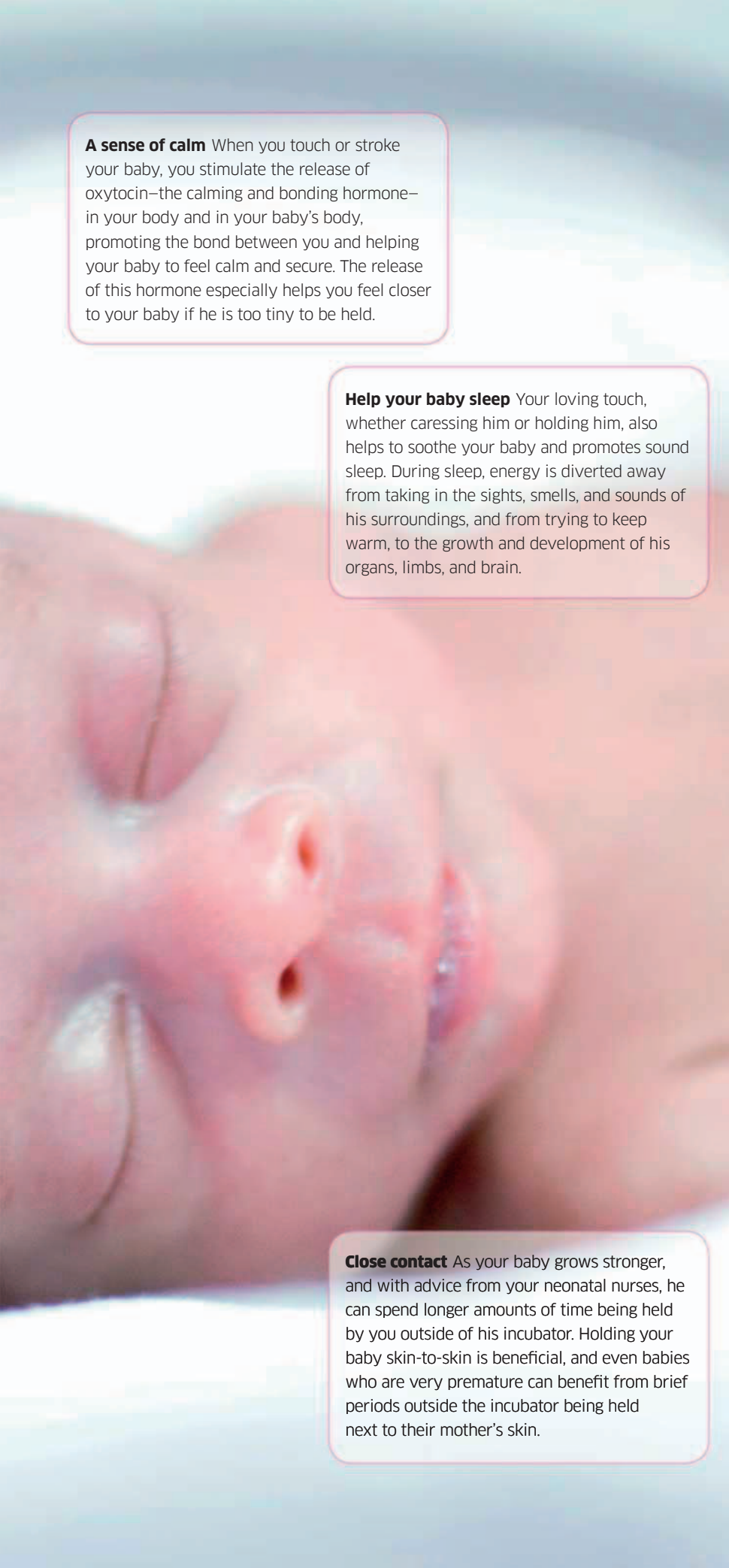




A sense of calm When you touch or stroke your baby, you stimulate the release of oxytocin—the calming and bonding hormone—in your body and in your baby's body, promoting the bond between you and helping your baby to feel calm and secure. The release of this hormone especially helps you feel closer to your baby if he is too tiny to be held.

Help your baby sleep Your loving touch, whether caressing him or holding him, also helps to soothe your baby and promotes sound sleep. During sleep, energy is diverted away from taking in the sights, smells, and sounds of his surroundings, and from trying to keep warm, to the growth and development of his organs, limbs, and brain.

Close contact As your baby grows stronger, and with advice from your neonatal nurses, he can spend longer amounts of time being held by you outside of his incubator. Holding your baby skin-to-skin is beneficial, and even babies who are very premature can benefit from brief periods outside the incubator being held next to their mother's skin.

FASCINATING FACTS

Touch has many benefits for both special-care baby and parents, also helping to promote a strong bond.

Boost immunity When held skin-to-skin, bacteria from the mother's skin colonize the baby, protecting him from germs.

Avoid PPD Mothers of special-care babies are more likely to suffer from postpartum depression. Oxytocin, released when you touch your baby, can help you avoid PPD.

Home early Premature babies held skin to skin are likely to need less time in the hospital. Studies also show better neurological-development scores at six and 12 months for premature babies who received kangaroo care.

Skin-to-skin contact Babies who receive kangaroo care (see below) are better able to regulate temperature, have improved oxygen levels, and breast-feed more easily.



Kangaroo care This is the practice of holding your naked baby against the skin of your chest, wrapped in a sling or cloth, snuggled upright on your chest. The technique was first used in Colombia in the 1980s when hospitals had no incubators to keep premature babies warm. With his face turned to one side, your baby can breathe easily and, crucially, maintain a warm body temperature.